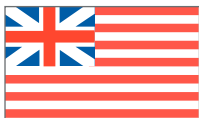


USA: Historical flags

The flags of the War of Independence and of the Civil War still have an influence on the American flags of today.



**THE GRAND
UNION FLAG**

The first American flag was adapted from the British Red Ensign of the time. It was known as the “Grand Union Flag,” i.e. of the Union of 13 colonies. These were represented by the 13 stripes of red and white. The flag was introduced in December 1775 for use on land and at sea.



**THE FIRST STARS
AND STRIPES**

On June 14, 1777, the Union Jack was removed from the flag in favor of a blue canton with 13 stars, representing a new constellation, which now also represented the United States. This was the first use of stars in this way, and set a precedent for many later flags.



**THE FLAG
OF 1795**

When two new states joined the Union in 1795, two new stars and two new stripes were added to the flag, making 15 stripes and 15 stars. This set a precedent for adding new stripes and stars when each new state joined the Union. The flag soon became known as the “Star Spangled Banner.”



**THE FLAG
OF 1818**

Five new states were formed after 1795, but a new flag was not designed until 1817 when Congress decreed that in future only new stars would be added and it would revert to 13 stripes, in order to preserve the appearance of the flag. The new stars were added on July 4, 1818, and this system has been followed ever since.



**THE STARS
AND BARS**

When Southern states seceded from the Union in 1860–61, a new flag for the Confederacy was hoisted on March 3, 1861. Known as the “Stars and Bars”, it originally had 7 stars, but these increased to 13 in the course of 1861, as more states joined the Confederacy.



**THE BATTLE FLAG OR
“FLAG OF THE SOUTH”**

The Battle Flag with its distinctive saltire on a red field (Southern Cross) was introduced in September 1861, specifically for use in battle. On land it was square with a white border, but the rectangular naval version, without a border, is now accepted as “The Flag of the South.”